



National University of Sciences and Technology (NUST)
School of Electrical Engineering and Computer Science

HU-115 – Principles of Sociology

Assignment 1

Sociological Analysis of a Movie

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THE PURSUIT OF HAPPYNESS

A SOCIOLOGICAL ANALYSIS

1. INTRODUCTION

The Pursuit of Happyness is a biographical drama based on the real-life experiences of **Chris Gardner**, who grew up without a father and later faces intense poverty, homelessness, unemployment, and social exclusion while raising his young son as a single parent. Chris earns a living by selling bone density scanners, but due to low market demand, delayed payments, and mounting financial pressure, he gradually falls into economic hardship. Eventually, his inability to pay rent results in eviction, forcing him and his son to survive in shelters, subway stations, and public spaces.

The **central sociological problem** portrayed in the film is **poverty and structural inequality**, showing how economic deprivation systematically restricts access to housing, education, employment, and dignity. The film highlights how **capitalist social structures, institutional failures, power imbalance, exploitation, alienation, and weak welfare systems** trap individuals in cycles of deprivation. It also challenges the ideology of meritocracy, revealing how social class, power, and opportunity profoundly shape life chances.

2. IDENTIFICATION OF CORE SOCIAL ISSUES

The film portrays multiple interconnected sociological problems:

A. POVERTY AND ECONOMIC INSECURITY

Despite continuous effort, Chris struggles to meet basic survival needs. His unstable income demonstrates how **hard work does not guarantee economic security** in capitalist systems.

B. HOMELESSNESS AND HOUSING INSECURITY

Failure to pay rent results in eviction, highlighting the **fragility of housing security** for low-income families and the absence of protective welfare mechanisms.

C. SOCIAL CLASS INEQUALITY AND POWER IMBALANCE

Chris occupies a **lower-class position**, while corporate executives represent economic elites. This power imbalance determines access to opportunity, respect, and stability.

D. INSTITUTIONAL FAILURE

Daycare centers, welfare systems, employment institutions, and housing authorities fail to provide adequate support, leading to **systemic breakdown**.

E. FAMILY BREAKDOWN AND SINGLE PARENTHOOD

Economic pressure leads to marital conflict and eventual separation, producing **single parenting**, emotional stress, and developmental challenges for the child.

3. MOVIE CHARACTERS

Character	Role in Story	Brief Description
Chris Gardner	Protagonist	A struggling salesman and devoted father who faces poverty, homelessness, and an unpaid internship while trying to secure a better future for his son. Represents resilience under structural inequality.
Christopher Gardner Jr.	Chris's Son	Innocent child affected by poverty and instability. Symbolizes vulnerability, intergenerational inequality, and the emotional cost of economic hardship.
Linda Gardner	Chris's Wife	Overworked mother employed in low-wage labor. Her emotional breakdown reflects economic stress, gender inequality, and the double burden on women.
Jay Twistle	Internship Manager	Corporate authority figure who evaluates interns. Represents institutional gatekeeping and meritocratic ideology.
Martin Frohm	Senior Executive	Symbol of corporate elite status and economic power. Represents upper-class dominance in capitalist systems.
Walter Ribbon	Senior Partner	Represents institutional authority and final decision-making power in determining social mobility.
Landlord	Property Owner	Evicts Chris due to unpaid rent. Symbolizes economic control over basic survival resources.
Daycare Provider (Mrs. Chu)	Caregiver	Runs an underperforming daycare center, reflecting institutional dysfunction and social neglect.

4. THEORETICAL ANALYSIS

The movie is analyzed using **three core sociological perspectives** from the lecture:

- Structural Functionalism
- Conflict Theory
- Symbolic Interactionism
(with integration of Social Exchange Theory and Feminist Perspective where applicable)

A. STRUCTURAL FUNCTIONALISM

Structural Functionalism views society as a **system of interconnected parts**; family, education, economy, and welfare institutions, that function together to maintain **social stability and balance**. When these parts fail, **dysfunction and disorder** emerge.

APPLICATION TO THE MOVIE:

1. Family as a Social Institution

Chris teaches his son social norms, such as affection, respect, and emotional bonding (e.g., “give me a kiss”), demonstrating the **socialization function of the family**. Parents transmit values that maintain social continuity.

2. Daycare System – Manifest Function & Failure

Daycare centers are meant to **educate, supervise, and socially develop children** (manifest function). However, the daycare shown fails, engaging children in passive activities such as television, indicating **institutional dysfunction**.

3. Organic Solidarity

Working parents depend on daycare staff, and daycare staff rely on parents for income. This mutual dependence reflects **organic solidarity**, where social cohesion is maintained through specialization and interdependence.

4. Institutional Failure

Chris occasionally resorts to stealing or avoiding transport fares, reflecting **functional strain**. Structural Functionalism explains such deviance as a **consequence of institutional breakdown**, not moral failure. Such institutional failures lead to crimes.

5. Broken Family & Single Parenting

The economic collapse of the family leads to separation, showing how **economic dysfunction destabilizes family structure**, negatively affecting child development.

B. CONFLICT THEORY (KARL MARX)

Conflict Theory argues that society is shaped by **class struggle over scarce resources**, where the bourgeoisie (elite) exploit the proletariat (workers). Inequality is maintained through **power, exploitation, and ideology**.

APPLICATION TO THE MOVIE:

1. Class Inequality & Alienation

When Chris observes stockbrokers and says *"They all looked so happy. Why couldn't I look like that?"*, it reflects **class alienation** — feeling powerless, disconnected, and excluded from economic prosperity. Stockbrokers and board of directors represent bourgeoisie and unpaid internees specifically Chris himself represent proletariat.

2. Exploitation & Unpaid Internship

Chris performs intense labor without pay, representing **capitalist exploitation**, where owners gain productivity without fair compensation.

3. Power Imbalance

Elite professionals control hiring, wealth, and institutional access. Chris lacks power, resources, and social capital, illustrating **structural domination**.

4. Ideology of Meritocracy

The belief that success depends solely on effort hides **structural barriers**, making poverty appear as personal failure rather than systemic injustice. This ideology protects elite dominance without force.

5. Competition for Scarce Resources

Interns compete for one job, demonstrating **class conflict** and limited social mobility.

C. SYMBOLIC INTERACTIONISM

Symbolic Interactionism focuses on **daily social interactions**, meanings, symbols, identity formation, and social labeling.

APPLICATION TO THE MOVIE:

1. Child Observing Parental Behavior

Chris's son observes his mother's frustration caused by unpaid bills, shaping his emotional understanding of stress, poverty, and insecurity — **social reality formed through observation**.

2. Looking-Glass Self

Chris perceives himself as intelligent and capable, despite repeated rejection. His self-concept is shaped through interactions, showing **Cooley's Looking-Glass Self**. He was good at math in school so he thinks he is good with numbers. The bone density scanners shows slightly better results for double the price but he still sells them which makes him think he is good with people.

3. Impression Management (Dramaturgical Analysis)

Chris carefully hides his homelessness from clients, dresses professionally, avoids mentioning financial distress, and says he was “just passing by” — classic **front-stage performance and impression management**.

4. Definition of the Situation

Chris modifies his behavior depending on social context — professional in office, vulnerable in private — reflecting how **situational meanings shape behavior**. After being homeless, Chris plays with his son talking about dinosaurs which changed his son's mood. Christopher jr. considers it an adventure rather than a calamity and enjoys the game.

5. CRITICAL ANALYSIS

4.1 CRITICAL ANALYSIS OF CHARACTERS

This part covers **deep sociological analysis** of selected characters, integrating theory directly with personality, behaviour, and structural position.

1. CHRIS GARDNER

Conflict Theory

Chris represents the **working-class individual trapped within capitalist structures**. Despite intelligence and effort, he lacks:

- Capital
- Social networks
- Institutional power

His unpaid internship demonstrates **labor exploitation**, where productivity is extracted without compensation. His homelessness reveals how **economic systems prioritize profit over human need**. Chris represents **alienation**, feeling disconnected from wealth, power, and social belonging.

Symbolic Interactionism

Chris constantly manages impressions:

- Professional suit despite homelessness

- Hiding financial struggle
- Approaching people on purpose and pretending it to be by chance.
- Hiding his tears while playing with his son

Using Goffman's **Dramaturgical Analysis**:

- **Front Stage:** Confident, competent intern
- **Back Stage:** Vulnerable, homeless father
- **Impression Management:** Strategic identity construction

His self-belief reflects **Looking-Glass Self** — he maintains a positive self-concept despite social rejection.

Structural Functionalism

Chris performs the **socialization function of the family**:

- Teaches affection (kissing and hugging his child)
- Protects child from harsh reality
- Attempts to maintain emotional stability

He fulfills family duties even when economic institutions fail.

2. LINDA GARDNER

Feminist Perspective

Linda represents the **working-class woman trapped in gendered labor inequality**:

- Works double shifts
- Performs domestic labor
- Receives low wages

Her labor is undervalued compared to corporate male professionals. The film shows **absence of women in managerial positions**, reinforcing patriarchal labor structures.

She experiences the **double burden**:

- Economic provider
- Emotional caretaker

Her emotional exhaustion is not weakness — it is structural oppression.

Social Exchange Theory

Her decision to leave can be analyzed as:

- Increasing emotional and economic cost
- Decreasing perceived reward

The relationship collapses when **cost outweighs benefit**.

Conflict Theory

Linda's class position intersects with gender, creating **compounded disadvantage**. She lacks upward mobility and access to institutional opportunity.

3. CHRISTOPHER JR.

Christopher represents the **most vulnerable social group: children in poverty**.

Structural Functionalism

Children depend on:

- Stable family
- Education
- Welfare institutions

All these systems weaken in his case, creating dysfunction.

Intergenerational Inequality

He experiences:

- Housing instability
- Emotional insecurity
- Social stigma

His life chances are shaped by his father's economic status — demonstrating **structural reproduction of inequality**.

4. JAY TWISTLE & CORPORATE EXECUTIVES

These characters represent the **elite class controlling access to opportunity**.

Conflict Theory

They:

- Determine who gets the job
- Control economic mobility
- Maintain hierarchical order

The internship system creates artificial scarcity (many interns, one job), reinforcing competition and inequality.

Ideology of Meritocracy

They reinforce the belief that:

“Only the best will succeed.” Board of directors don’t see the hard work, efforts or potential. They are just concerned with what one can bring to the table.

This narrative hides structural privilege and makes inequality appear fair and natural.

5. LANDLORD

The landlord’s behavior reflects:

Conflict Theory

- Ownership of property = power
- Ability to evict = class dominance

Housing becomes a tool of control.

Social Exchange Theory

Once rent stops, benefit disappears. Relationship ends.

Human need is secondary to economic calculation.

6. DAYCARE PROVIDER

Structural Functionalism

Daycare has a **manifest function**:

- Child supervision
- Social development

However, children are made to watch television passively, she makes kids watch love island on tv rather than actually providing them the care and environment she is charging parents for, indicating **institutional dysfunction**.

Organic Solidarity (Durkheim).

Working parents depend on daycare; daycare depends on fees. When the system fails, children suffer.

4.2 LOGICAL LINKING OF EVENTS WITH THEORY

This section provides a **detailed sociological interpretation of key movie scenes**, logically connecting them with **multiple sociological theories** to explain how individual experiences reflect broader social structures and systemic inequalities.

1. EVICTION SCENE (CONFLICT THEORY + SOCIAL EXCHANGE THEORY)

Scene Description:

Chris and his son are evicted from their apartment due to delayed rent payments, despite Chris repeatedly explaining his financial hardship. The landlord shows no empathy and strictly enforces contractual obligations.

Sociological Analysis:

From the perspective of **Conflict Theory**, this scene highlights **economic power imbalance and class domination**. The landlord represents the **property-owning class**, possessing economic power and legal authority, while Chris belongs to the **working class**, lacking financial security and bargaining power. This unequal power relationship allows the landlord to impose harsh decisions without considering Chris's circumstances. Housing becomes a **commodity**, controlled by those with capital, while the poor face housing insecurity. This reflects Marx's argument that social order primarily protects **property rights and elite interests**, rather than human welfare.

Simultaneously, **Social Exchange Theory** explains the interaction through **cost-benefit calculations**. The landlord's cooperation depends entirely on receiving rent (reward). Once Chris fails to pay, the **cost outweighs the benefit**, resulting in termination of the housing relationship. Emotional appeals, moral considerations, or social empathy are overridden by economic logic. This demonstrates how **market-based social relations weaken human bonds**, turning survival needs into transactional exchanges.

Critical Insight:

The scene powerfully exposes how **capitalist systems prioritize profit and contract over compassion**, pushing vulnerable individuals into homelessness. It illustrates how structural inequality operates at everyday levels, transforming housing from a basic human need into a mechanism of social exclusion.

2. MARITAL BREAKDOWN (SOCIAL EXCHANGE THEORY + STRUCTURAL FUNCTIONALISM)

Scene Description:

Chris's wife becomes increasingly frustrated due to unpaid bills, emotional exhaustion, and continuous financial instability. Eventually, she leaves the family to seek better economic security, resulting in family disintegration.

Sociological Analysis:

From **Social Exchange Theory**, marital relationships are viewed as ongoing **evaluations of rewards and costs**. In the early stages, emotional companionship, shared goals, and family bonding provide strong rewards. However, as financial hardship intensifies, **psychological stress, exhaustion, and insecurity**

become overwhelming costs. When costs exceed perceived benefits, the relationship weakens and eventually collapses. Chris's wife perceives continued sacrifice without tangible improvement, leading her to exit the relationship in pursuit of survival and stability.

From a **Structural Functionalist perspective**, the breakdown of the family signifies **institutional dysfunction**. The family, as a key social institution, is expected to provide **emotional support, economic cooperation, and child stability**. However, economic stress destabilizes the family structure, weakening its functional capacity. This illustrates how **economic systems directly shape family organization**, demonstrating that private family problems are deeply rooted in public economic conditions.

Critical Insight:

This scene reveals that **economic deprivation not only destroys material security but also erodes emotional bonds**, destabilizing the core social institution of family. It challenges romanticized views of marriage, showing how **structural pressures override emotional commitment**, especially among marginalized populations.

3. OFFICE CULTURE (FEMINIST PERSPECTIVE + CONFLICT THEORY)

Scene Description:

The stock brokerage firm is dominated by men in managerial and professional positions. Meanwhile, Chris's wife works double shifts in low-paid labor-intensive jobs yet remains economically insecure.

Sociological Analysis:

From a **Feminist Perspective**, the absence of women in leadership roles reflects **systemic gender inequality** and **patriarchal labor structures**. High-status corporate positions are occupied almost exclusively by men, while women are confined to **low-wage, labor-intensive, and insecure employment sectors**. Chris's wife's double shifts symbolize the **double burden** faced by working-class women: economic labor combined with domestic responsibilities, without adequate financial or institutional support.

Simultaneously, **Conflict Theory** explains this gender stratification as part of **broader power hierarchies**, where dominant groups (men + economic elites) control access to wealth and authority. Women's labor is undervalued, reinforcing their economic dependence and limiting upward mobility.

Critical Insight:

This scene highlights how **class inequality intersects with gender inequality**, creating compounded disadvantage for women. It reveals that economic hardship is **gendered**, disproportionately burdening women and reinforcing patriarchal power structures within capitalist systems.

4. MOVING ASSISTANCE (SOCIAL EXCHANGE THEORY + SYMBOLIC INTERACTIONISM)

Scene Description:

A man helps Chris move his belongings, motivated largely by Chris's unpaid debt of \$14.

Sociological Analysis:

From **Social Exchange Theory**, this interaction reflects **reciprocal obligation**, where assistance is provided not purely out of altruism but due to **expected reward or repayment**. The helper calculates the **potential benefit of recovering the money**, making cooperation economically rational.

From **Symbolic Interactionism**, this small monetary debt becomes a **symbol of moral obligation**, shaping social interaction. The helper interprets the debt as a reason for engagement, while Chris interprets the assistance as both economic relief and emotional validation.

Critical Insight:

This scene demonstrates how **economic scarcity reshapes social relationships**, turning even basic human support into calculated exchanges. It reflects how **poverty commodifies social interaction**, eroding spontaneous kindness and reinforcing transactional logic.

5. INTERNSHIP STRUGGLE (CONFLICT THEORY + SYMBOLIC INTERACTIONISM + DRAMATURGICAL ANALYSIS)

Scene Description:

Chris persistently pursues an unpaid internship, repeatedly visiting corporate offices, solving a Rubik's cube to impress superiors, networking aggressively, and carefully managing his appearance and behavior to hide homelessness.

Sociological Analysis:

From **Conflict Theory**, this scene reflects **intense class struggle**. Chris competes against elite candidates who possess superior education, financial security, and social networks. His extraordinary effort highlights how **working-class individuals must exert disproportionate labor to access limited opportunity**, reinforcing structural inequality. The unpaid nature of the internship further exposes **labor exploitation**, where productivity is extracted without compensation, benefiting corporate elites. Chris tries his best to prove that he is good with numbers and good with people (two important requirements highlighted by stockbroker).

From **Symbolic Interactionism**, Chris engages in **impression management**, carefully controlling symbols such as clothing, language, and body posture to appear professional and competent. He avoids revealing his homelessness, reshaping how others perceive his identity.

Through **Dramaturgical Analysis (Goffman)**:

- **Front Stage:** Confident, professional performance at the office.
- **Back Stage:** Emotional exhaustion, homelessness, and vulnerability.
- **Impression Management:** Strategic self-presentation to avoid stigma and exclusion.

Critical Insight:

This scene reveals the **psychological labor of survival**, where marginalized individuals must constantly perform social acceptability to access opportunity. It exposes the **emotional cost of inequality**, highlighting how poverty forces individuals into continuous self-surveillance, performance, and concealment.

OVERALL CRITICAL EVALUATION

Collectively, these scenes demonstrate how **individual suffering is produced by structural forces**, not personal failure. They reveal how **capitalist economic systems, institutional breakdown, gender inequality, and power imbalances** shape daily experiences, relationships, identity, and opportunity.

The film thus transforms personal struggle into a **powerful sociological narrative of structural inequality, social exclusion, and resilience**, making it a profound critique of modern capitalist society.

6. REFLECTION & SOCIETAL IMPLICATIONS

DETAILED REFLECTION

The movie presents a powerful and emotionally intense reflection on the realities of life within a capitalist society, exposing how economic systems often prioritize profit and efficiency over human dignity and social welfare. Through Chris's journey, the film forces the viewer to confront the harsh truth that survival in modern society is less about merit and hard work, and more about access to resources, social connections, and structural opportunity.

One of the most disturbing reflections is how **poverty becomes criminalized**. Chris is not homeless because of laziness or incompetence, but due to systemic barriers such as unpaid internships, lack of affordable housing, and unstable employment. Yet, society treats him as a failure. His constant fear of being arrested, evicted, or socially rejected highlights how economic vulnerability strips individuals of basic human security. This reflects a system where poverty is punished rather than addressed, pushing struggling individuals further into social exclusion.

The film also demonstrates how **economic instability weakens family structures**. Financial stress slowly destroys Chris's marriage, not because of emotional failure, but because prolonged economic pressure exhausts emotional resilience. This shows that poverty does not only affect material well-being but deeply damages relationships, emotional health, and psychological stability. The breakdown of the family reveals how capitalism indirectly destabilizes personal bonds by forcing individuals into constant survival mode.

A deeply moving aspect of the film is its portrayal of **childhood under poverty**. Chris's son experiences homelessness, food insecurity, and emotional confusion at an age when children should feel safety and

comfort. Despite Chris's efforts to protect him, the child is exposed to harsh realities that can leave lasting emotional scars. This reflects the concept of **intergenerational inequality**, where children born into poverty inherit disadvantage, limiting their opportunities and shaping their future trajectories. The film makes it painfully clear that a child's life chances are often determined at birth, not by talent or intelligence.

The movie also challenges the myth of **meritocracy** — the belief that success is purely the result of talent and effort. Although Chris works relentlessly, his survival depends largely on chance encounters, social networking, and access to elite institutional spaces. This exposes how capitalist societies often glorify success stories while ignoring the countless individuals who work equally hard but never escape poverty due to structural constraints. The narrative suggests that society celebrates rare exceptions to justify a system that systematically disadvantages the majority.

From a gender perspective, the film highlights **structural gender inequality** through the character of Chris's wife, who performs physically exhausting labor for minimal pay while simultaneously managing domestic responsibilities. Her double burden reflects how women in lower economic classes face intensified exploitation, both at work and at home. The emotional toll of this burden is evident in her breakdown, reinforcing feminist critiques of labor inequality and gendered economic oppression.

Although in the long run Chris gets rich by founding his investment firm, gardening rich and selling a minority stake in multimillion dollars, but Chris was the only one out of 20 people who got that unpaid internship that took him to this level.

Overall, the movie acts as a **social critique of capitalism**, revealing how economic systems shape human dignity, relationships, childhood development, and psychological well-being. It invites viewers to question existing power structures and reconsider social responsibility toward marginalized populations. Rather than presenting poverty as an individual failure, the film powerfully frames it as a **systemic injustice**, urging society to move toward compassion, equity, and structural reform.

KEY SOCIETAL IMPLICATIONS:

Following are the key social implications of this movie:

- **Economic Inequality and Social Fragmentation**

Widening class disparities divide society into unequal social worlds, limiting mobility and weakening social cohesion.

- **Institutional Failure and Structural Strain**

Weak housing protection, unpaid labor systems, and inadequate welfare support contribute to homelessness and survival-based deviance, showing that instability often stems from structural failure rather than individual fault.

- **Meritocracy as Ideological Justification**

The belief that success depends solely on effort obscures structural barriers and legitimizes inequality by framing poverty as personal failure.

- **Gendered Economic Burden**

Working-class women face both low-wage labor exploitation and domestic responsibilities, reinforcing patriarchal inequalities and economic vulnerability.

- **Intergenerational Reproduction of Inequality**

Children born into poverty inherit structural disadvantage, making inequality cyclical rather than accidental.

POLICY-LEVEL REFLECTION:

The film advocates for:

- Universal housing protection
- Paid internship policies
- Living wages
- Accessible childcare
- Strong welfare systems
- Gender-equitable labor laws

7. CONCLUSION

The Pursuit of Happyness operates as a powerful sociological case study of structural poverty, class inequality, gendered labor, and institutional failure. Through Structural Functionalism, Conflict Theory, Symbolic Interactionism, Social Exchange Theory, and Feminist perspectives, the film demonstrates that individual struggle is deeply embedded within broader systems of power, ideology, and economic organization. Chris Gardner's journey illustrates that resilience alone does not eliminate inequality; rather, opportunity is shaped by access to resources, institutional support, and social positioning. Ultimately, the film challenges the myth of purely merit-based success and calls for structural reform that prioritizes equity, dignity, and social justice over market efficiency.